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Original Page: 249**Culture (OWC):** [San \(FX10\)](#)**Region:** Africa**Sub Region:** Southern Africa**Field Date:** 1950-1961**Coverage Date:** 1950-1961**Place Coverage:** Nyae Nyae Region, Namibia And Botswana**Section Title(S):** A SITTING AVOIDANCE

A SITTING AVOIDANCE

The !Kung like to be close together. When women and girls sit together they tend to huddle, touching one another shoulder to shoulder, knee to knee, ankles overlapping. Boys and young men sit this way also, but to do so is not so common among old men. Men and women often sit in separate groups. They may also sit in the same group, fairly close together, but they will not huddle so close as to be touching each other. In general, men and women maintain some degree of separation in sitting. This separation is not due to reserved behavior, but rather to the !Kung belief that it is dangerous for men to sit where women have sat previously, and vice versa. They believe that if the genitalia of a man were to touch a spot on the ground that a woman's genitalia had touched (regardless of whether or not the men or women were clothed), his prowess as a hunter would be destroyed. A woman whose genitalia touched a spot on the ground where an old man had been sitting would suffer disorders of her urinary tract and would pass blood in her urine. Women avoid sitting where old or young men have sat, but to sit where old men have sat is the more dangerous. At the family fire men sit on one side (to the right of a person facing across the fire toward the opening of the shelter), women on the other.

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None of the !Kung are prevented by this belief or by the rules of reserved behavior from touching each other in many other ways. They cut each other's hair, groom each other's heads for lice, lean over each other to rearrange ornaments that are out of place, rub each other with fat.

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There was so much physical contact that it was hard to see where reserved behavior came in at all. Informants explained it, however. They said that propriety permitted them to sit in the lap or even between the legs of a !gun!a, but they must not assume such a position with anyone they could not joke with. They demonstrated the proper distance that should be maintained: one must not sit closer to a tsu or a //ga than about eighteen inches, they claimed; a mother-in-law and father-in-law should keep a distance of about three feet between themselves and their son-in-law or daughter-in-law. The !Kung may not always have been as scrupulous about keeping a distance of eighteen inches as they were ■250 when we asked them to demonstrate what was proper, but the idea of practicing constraint in physical contact with people whom one “respects” is definitely present.

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